A Mindfulness Guide for Neurodivergent Individuals

Presence Practice Workbook



Theodoros Bairaktaris

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Based on the Fourfold Axis: Body · Breath · Attention · Space

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> **A note before you begin.** The exercises that follow are self-regulation tools — they are not a substitute for therapy, diagnosis, or medication. If at any point your emotions overwhelm you, or you feel intense discomfort, stop the exercise, open your eyes, and feel the soles of your feet on the ground. The support of a therapist can prove valuable. The practice of presence has compassion at its core.

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Introduction

Who Is This Guide For?

This guide is for those who feel disconnected — those whose mind races without pause, whose body lives in constant alertness, and for whom calm feels like a foreign language.

It is a tool for people who live with the impact of trauma, with neurodivergence (such as ADHD), or simply with the chronic pressure of modern life.

> *You do not need to "fix" anything in yourself, because nothing is broken. The goal is to learn to return, gently and kindly, to your living presence.*

A Note on the Wisdom of the Body

The mind has no sense of "now." It travels ceaselessly between memories of the past and projections of the future.

The body, by contrast — through undeniable gravity and breath — is always here. For those of us who have felt disconnected, returning to the present is not merely a psychological exercise but an embodied journey of reconnection.

Personal Note — A Journey, Not a Theory

This guide was not born in a laboratory or an academic office. It was born of a personal need. When my son received his diagnosis, I realised that I am neurodivergent too — only that in my day they called me "hyperactive."

We needed something practical: a method of self-regulation that does not ask us to fight our brain, but to work with it. I turned to mindfulness, because I had read that it helps. The modern methods I found were built

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to the measure of a mind that did not resemble mine. So I set out to find their source — and I knew how to look, because esotericism had been my special interest since childhood.

There I found the opposite of what I expected. The sources were not asking for a quiet mind. They were offering a method for meeting your own mind as it is and reconnecting with it. That was precisely what had fallen away on the road to the diluted versions — and it was the one thing I needed.

What remained was the translation. Not of the method, but of its shape: these traditions assume time, stillness, a teacher in the room, years of gradual practice. And they do not answer questions that were never put to them — sensory overload, hyperfocus, a system that shuts down. What holds from these exercises when attention settles nowhere, when the body is already overloaded, when stillness is itself the discomfort.

This is the book. I am not a teacher. The practice came from elsewhere; the translation is mine, and so is the responsibility for it.

> *"My mind didn't stop racing, but it stopped carrying me away."*

How We Define Mindfulness

Mindfulness is not a mysterious "something" to be achieved. It is the natural experience that arises when the four main centers of consciousness function simultaneously and harmoniously.

BODY	The sense that we inhabit a body that touches, feels, and connects to the earth through gravity.
BREATH	Awareness of our rhythm of living — the continuous flow of inhale and exhale that connects us to the world.

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ATTENTION	The ability to direct the light of our awareness — to focus, to open, or to observe.
SPACE	The sense of the open field within and around us, in which thoughts, feelings, and sensations appear and disappear.

When we are under pressure or scattered, these centers may function separately or even in conflict. The method that follows is simple: to come into contact with each center individually and then attune them so they work in parallel. We do not change ourselves. We attune and make room for what is already there.

How to Use This Guide

- The exercises have the quality of play. There are no mistakes, only experiments.
- Presence does not need to last hours. It begins with victories of a few seconds.
- The instructions are clear, but do not hesitate to adapt them to your needs.
- Consistency in small doses matters more than duration.

In the section "The Spiritual Background" and in the resources at the end of the book, you will meet names from contemplative traditions. They are cited there as the historical sources of the exercises, just as we would cite the researcher behind a study. No belief is required — and none is proposed. The method stands entirely on observation and on your own experience.

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Companion app: Every exercise in this book also exists in interactive, animated form at neurodivergent-mindfulness.org. For audio — binaural beats and calm soundscapes that support regulation — see the audio space. The app is free, with no account and no tracking.

If, during the exercises, your emotions overwhelm you or cause intense discomfort, the support of a therapist can prove valuable. The practice of presence has compassion at its core.

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Part 1 — The Core of the Method



The axis descends from the crown of the head to the centre of the Earth.

The Fourfold Axis: Body · Breath · Attention · Space

The next four chapters introduce you to the four centers of consciousness that form the core of this practice. Each chapter includes theoretical background, practical exercises, and space for reflection.

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Chapter 1 — Body: The Stability of "Here"

> **In this chapter**
>
> *The body is the undeniable ground of the present moment. We learn to sense gravity, our posture, and our contact with space — as the starting point of every practice.*

Grounding through gravity — our stable base.

The Beginning: Relaxation and Grounding

The practice of the Fourfold Axis always begins with the body. The body is our stable base, the undeniable "Here" that connects us to the present. We begin with conscious grounding, because relaxation precedes awareness.

Our body is not merely a vehicle. It is a living archive of our experiences. The posture we have formed often carries the rejection, the disappointment, and the tension we lived through because we felt different. These experiences get "locked in" as chronic tightness in the shoulders, the back, the pelvis, and the jaw.

Gravity: The Undeniable "Here"

Gravity is not merely a force — it is the proof of "Here." It shows us, beyond any doubt, exactly the point at which we can exist in space, at this particular moment. Grounding is the first act of relaxation.

> *True grounding (Body) is achieved only within a space that we feel holds us. Body and space work together.*

Our Aim

The aim is not a specific, perfect posture, nor the end of our thoughts. The aim is to be comfortable, grounded, and relaxed within our body.

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The Body, Space, and the Sense of Safety

Deep relaxation within the body is never an isolated act. It always presupposes awareness of space. Our body, through the sense organs, continually informs us of our position within space.

When space is perceived as open and receptive, the body is given permission to let go of tightness and relax. True grounding is achieved only within a space that we feel holds us.

Escaping the Concepts

When the mind has no stable, undeniable base in the present, it often falls into the trap of internal analysis and scenarios. Focusing on Gravity gives us the ability to step out of these mental scenarios.

Analysis and observation happen over time, after stability is present. The content of the mechanical mind is recognized and let go if it is not useful or is harmful, without the need for analysis. The open mind neither analyzes nor judges — it unites and understands causes.

> ***The Undeniable "Here" and the Ceaseless Flow:*** *While Gravity gives us an unshakable "Here," on a larger scale there is only movement and flow (like the Earth around the Sun). Mindfulness teaches us to embrace both poles: the stability of Gravity and the ceaseless flow of life.*

An important note on time: Changing posture and tension takes considerable time — the habit was built over years and the body has been molded. Do not rush and do not push yourself. Persistence in gentleness is the greatest act of self-regulation.

Practice: The Book / Box

- **Position:** Stand comfortably upright.
- **Prop (optional):** Take a book or box and place it on your head.

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- **Focus:** Notice how you need to stand so it doesn't fall. Feel how the weight descends smoothly through the neck, the spine, and the pelvis.
- **Sensation:** Feel the weight, the touch of the soles on the ground, and the sense of the axis that keeps you upright.

> **In the app:** Grounding exercise with guidance · Body microdoses · for movement, Swaying and Cloud Hands (Tai Chi).

Reflection: After the exercise, what did I notice in my body?

> ★ **Key Point: Gravity is always here. The body is always here. This is enough to begin.**

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Chapter 2 — Breath: The Rhythm of Life

> **In this chapter**
>
> *The breath connects us to the rhythm of life and teaches the acceptance of impermanence. Each inhale and exhale is a small rehearsal of beginning and ending.*

The breath as a bridge between body and world.

If the body unites us with the earth, the breath connects us to the sky and to the ceaseless flow of the world. It is the rhythm that accompanies us from birth to the end.

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The Rhythm of Existence



The in-breath receives, the out-breath releases; the weight keeps descending.

Observing the breath teaches us the natural rhythm of existence and the acceptance of impermanence. Each inhale is held for a moment and then released with the exhale.

- **INHALE** — The Beginning: birth, receiving.
- **PAUSE** — The Moment: existing in the now.
- **EXHALE** — The Ending: release, acceptance.

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> *This is crucial for the neurodivergent mind: when we feel an intense emotion, it can feel permanent. By observing the rhythm of the breath, we learn that every state is passing.*

The Act of Observation — Inner Touch

The first step is acceptance. You do not need to control your breath. It is enough to observe it as it is: deep or shallow, slow or fast, free or tight.

- In the sensation of air touching the nostrils
- In the expansion and contraction of the chest
- In the movement of the belly
- In the small shift of posture with each inhale and exhale

> ***The breath as an Indicator:*** *If it is tight or shallow, it signals tension. If it is slow and deep, it signals relaxation. The breath is the indicator of our inner state.*

The Three Rhythms

Throughout this book you will meet three breathing rhythms. They are not in competition: each has its own job.

| Rhythm | When | What it does |

|---|---|---|

| **5-5** (inhale 5, exhale 5) | daily, in a neutral state | balance and stabilisation; unsteady air becomes a current |

| **4-6** (inhale 4, exhale 6) | at the peak, when the wind picks up | the longer exhale tells the nervous system "we are safe" |

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| **4-2-7** (inhale 4, hold 2, exhale 7) | in a quiet moment, for deep relaxation | a pause and a very long exhale; the strongest regulator |

In the app you will also find the 4-7-8 variation, which works on the same principle as 4-2-7: a long exhale after a pause.

One rule holds for all three: **the exhale is the tool, not the inhale.** You never need to force air in.

Regulating in Intense Anxiety

In moments of intense anxiety or overload, the breath can become an immediate tool of regulation. We let the exhale leave through the mouth, a little more slowly and drawn out. We allow the belly to soften and draw slightly inward.

The Winds of Emotion

We have seen the breath as an indicator. But there is a second, older reading: **emotions are winds.** They are not ideas in the head — they are weather phenomena in the body and in the breath. That is where we can read them, before we find words for them.

- **Anger** — a strong, rising wind: it swells the chest, lifts and shallows the breath.
- **Anxiety** — a wind that keeps changing direction: breath erratic, short, without rhythm.
- **Sadness** — stillness and damp: the air grows heavy, the breath thins out, with sighs that come on their own.
- **Numbness** — dense fog in motionless air: breath so faint it is almost forgotten.
- **Calm and joy** — a light, steady breeze: breath deep and effortless. The map is not all bad weather.

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> *If the question "what do you feel?" brings you a blank, nothing is missing in you. You were simply being asked to translate the weather into words, without first being taught to observe it.*

First we read the weather. What wind is it? Where do I feel it in the body? How long has it been blowing? Without "why," without stories — only the weather, now. Recognition is already regulation: a wind you have seen does not govern you the way a wind you deny governs you.

Then we accompany the wind. We do not stop it — we give it rhythm:

- **At its peak** (rising anger, anxiety breaking loose): we lengthen the exhale — inhale for 4, exhale for 6. The long exhale tells the nervous system "we are safe."
- **When it eases a little:** balanced breath — 5 in, 5 out. The erratic air becomes a current.
- **Chanting or humming** on the exhale: a long exhale with vibration — the body calms the body. If you already hum instinctively when under pressure, you knew this before you read it.

Gusts, Systems, Climate

An honest word: not all winds obey the same tools.

- **Gusts** (minutes): a sudden irritation, a wave of anxiety. The breath softens them right away.
- **Weather systems** (days): the anger or the pain after a rejection may still be blowing tomorrow. If the breaths do not put it out, you have not failed — this wind has its own duration. Here the aim changes: not to change the weather, but to keep the vessel afloat. Food, sleep, someone to talk to, reading the weather again. That is success.
- **Climate** (years): the long patterns that come from far back. They are not solved in a day — and for the deeper ones, the company of a

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professional is worth it. But knowing your climate changes the in-between: when the wind rises out of all proportion to its cause, you don't conclude "something is wrong with me" — you recognize "I know this pattern." The pain remains; what leaves is the second pain, the confusion and the self-blame.

> *None of this means you are broken. It means you have weather — like everyone. Now you also have a map.*

> **In the Rabbit Hole:** Learning to Ride the Wind — breath and mind as wind and rider in the tsa lung tradition.

Practice: The Active Return

- **Grounding (Body):** Stand or sit comfortably. Feel gravity, the contact with the ground.
- **Awareness (Breath):** Turn your attention to the inhale and exhale. Feel the air touching the nostrils.
- **On the exhale:** Let the belly gather gently inward, as if releasing all the tension along with the air.
- **Acceptance:** Do not try to change the breath. Awareness is enough.
- **Regulation (optional):** If you feel very anxious, let the exhale leave through the mouth more slowly and drawn out.

The Axis of Presence

With its movement, the breath strengthens the axis of presence that rests on gravity. It works as a counterweight to the flow of thoughts: while the mind may race, the breath keeps the body in the now.

The tool here is twofold: to recognize the rhythm and quality of your breath, and to feel how its movement supports the body–gravity axis, bringing you back against the flow of thoughts.

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> *The breath teaches us to observe without intervening. This ability is the bridge to the next step: Attention.*

In the app: Guided 4-7-8 breathing with an animated inhale/exhale guide · Breath microdoses.

Reflection: How was my breath during the exercise? (fast/slow, shallow/deep, tight/free)

> ★ **Key Point: I observe without intervening. Every breath is a new beginning.**

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Chapter 3 — Attention: The Lens of Consciousness

> **In this chapter**
>
> *Attention is the lens of the mind — it can focus, open, or scatter. We learn to recognize where it is and to return it gently, without self-criticism.*

Attention as a lens that illuminates the present moment.

Attention is the third center of consciousness and the tool that determines where the mind will rest. The body is the base, the breath the rhythm, and attention is the lens that illuminates the present moment.

The Four Forms of Attention

Closed Attention. The beam gathers to a single point. Useful for concentration. E.g., you look steadily at an object.

Open Attention. The beam widens and illuminates many things at once. You hear the sounds, feel the body, breathe — all held within the same awareness.



Closed attention: the beam gathers to a single point.



Open attention: the same light, without direction.

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Scattered Attention. Attention resembles a monkey leaping from branch to branch. The aim is not to "kill" it but to rein it in gently.

Stuck Attention. The beam sticks to an external object or to a mental content: a thought, a worry. Excessive self-reference ("why do I feel this way? what does it mean?") is its characteristic form. This is the state that deserves the most attention, and the next section is devoted to it.

Stuck Attention, Up Close

The beam locks and the world around it disappears — space, body, time. Note that this is not the same as hyperfocus, which can also be a gift. Stuck attention is attention that cannot leave when you want it to.

The Vicious Circles: "Otherwise" and "Should"

Where exactly does the beam get stuck? Most often, in two patterns:

- **"How things could have been"** — the mind replays the past with a different script: if I had said, if I had done, if it had gone otherwise.
- **"How things should be"** — the mind compares the real with an ideal: this is how the day, the work, other people, I myself should have been.

These patterns are circles that lead nowhere — not out of weakness, but by construction: they compare the real with something that does not exist, and the non-existent never answers. The beam can circle the same orbit for hours without arriving anywhere.

And they do something more: **they sustain and enlarge emotions.** Remember the winds of the previous chapter. A wind that would have died down on its own within minutes is re-inflated by the circle every time it starts to fall — the circle is the bellows of the wind. That is why some emotions last for days: it is not the weather that blows, it is we who blow.

The exit is not to analyze the circle — "why am I thinking this?" is itself a circle. The exit is recognizing the orbit: you see that the beam has entered

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the familiar turn, you give it a label — **"Otherwise"** or **"Should"** — and you return gently to the stable point. You do not need to win the argument with the non-existent. It is enough to see that it is an argument with the non-existent.

> *If these circles are very familiar to you, it is not a flaw of logic — it is the over-functioning of an ability. The mind that runs scenarios is the same mind that predicts, plans, creates. And the "should" is often not even yours: it is years of others' expectations speaking in your voice. We do not fight the engine of scenarios — we learn to see when it is spinning in the void.*

Fourfold Attention

At this stage, attention becomes fourfold — we hold awareness of four levels at once:

- **Body** — which gives base and stability to the present moment.
- **Breath** — which gives rhythm and returns us to the now.
- **Attention Itself** — which learns to stabilize, to observe where it goes.
- **Thoughts** — which are recognized without carrying us away — simply observed.

The Power of the Label (Thought Labelling)

When a thought pulls you in, simply returning to the breath can be difficult. The labeling technique gives you an intermediate step: instead of engaging with the content of the thought, give it a simple, one-word label and then return to the stable point.

- Thinking about what you have to do tomorrow → **"Planning"**
- Thinking about something you said that was wrong → **"Criticism"** or **"Past"**
- Worrying about something in the future → **"Worry"** or **"Scenario"**

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Practice: Stabilizing the Lens

- **Body & Breath:** Stand or sit comfortably. Close your eyes. Feel your body and the rhythm of your breath.
- **Stable Point:** Open your eyes and choose a point of focus (visual, auditory, or bodily).
- **Fourfold Awareness:** Hold your attention there, while keeping awareness of body, breath, and thought-forms.
- **Gentle Return:** If you drift, recognize it (with a label if needed) and return gently: body → breath → stable point.

> **In the app:** Attention microdoses to train the lens.

Reflection: The journey of my attention — where does it tend to "stick" or to "race"?

> ★ **Key Point: The return of attention is not failure — it is the exercise itself. Every "gentle return" builds new neural pathways.**

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Chapter 4 — Space: Open Awareness

> **In this chapter**
>
> *The first three centers were something you do. Space is something that already is. Here we get to know awareness — the open field within which experience happens — and we learn to rest in it.*

Space gives us the capacity to hold it all.

The Body gave us stability, the Breath rhythm, Attention the return. All three are acts — something you direct. The fourth is of a different nature: not one more technique, but the discovery of the field within which the first three were working.

How You Drive

Think of how you drive. Your attention is closed on the road ahead — that is where you keep precision. Alongside it, an open, peripheral attention sees farther, right, left; and at intervals, the mirrors — behind. Ahead, around, behind, all at once. These are not two skills you alternate; they are one contact with the world, in which closed attention gives the point and open attention gives the space within which the point has meaning.

Notice what happens when you "leave" into a thought. The periphery goes dark, the mirrors are forgotten — and the most insidious part: even that "ahead" blurs. You did not trade width for precision; you lost both. Open awareness you already know — you simply forget it when you close in.

The Point and the Field

Attention is the point. It always takes a local, bounded piece — a room, an area, a thought — gives it a name and a border, and it tires, because it works. **Awareness** is the field within which the point moves: cosmic space — without border, without name, without a clear edge. It does not choose, it holds nothing; it simply knows — which is why it does not tire. The

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difference is not size: a country is vast, but it remains bounded. Awareness is not a larger piece — it is the boundless within which all the pieces fit.

Our usual state is absorption in the contents: a thought comes and we become the thought. The fourth step is a shift of the center: from the point, to the field. Until now you were the lens moving from object to object; now, by opening the periphery with the axis of gravity at its center, you become the space in which the lens works. In experience, you add nothing — you stop covering it over.

It is a shift from the **egocentric** to the **spatiocentric**. Egocentrically, everything revolves around me. Spatiocentrically, I move within something vast, and each thing exists at its own rhythm, independent of me — just as, in truth, the sun does not "rise"; the earth turns and brings me into the light.

That is why the first three steps were needed: the practice stabilizes the ground, and on stable ground awareness recognizes itself. First the earth, then the sky.

You Have Already Met It

Remember the "gentle return" of Chapter 3. The mind drifts, and at some point comes that "ah — I had been lost." The return you made yourself. But the moment of recognition was made by no one — if you could decide it, you would not have been lost. It arose on its own.

Researchers of mind-wandering call it meta-awareness: the moment the mind notices, on its own, where it is. No one produces it; it appears. The fourth stage does not ask you to acquire something new — it asks you to notice what was alerting you from the very beginning.

The Tunnel: A Source That Needs Care

This closed, intense focus — the tunnel — is not an enemy. For many of us it is the strongest tool we have: the place where we concentrate, work, create. The issue is not to abandon it, but whether it is *caring for* you while

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you are inside it: whether it rests on a grounded body and rest — or whether it is burning you.

When left uncared for, without body and breath, the periphery goes dark and the center blurs; there it stops being a source and becomes a trap. (The same in intense anxiety: the mind narrows and magnifies the threat — Chapter 8.) The fourth step does not extinguish the tunnel; it *cares for* it. You open the periphery, you ground, you rest — and you re-enter clear, not burnt. Open awareness does not replace focus; it is the place where focus refills.

The Space That Dwells in Truth

This field you do not imagine. The four anchors are not constructions of the mind: the earth holds you with its gravity whether you remember it or not, the air moves in and out on its own, light and space exist before you. They are truths, not images — that is why they have stability and rhythm. An image you make flickers and takes effort; a truth simply is there — you do not hold it, it holds you.

Here lies the most common misunderstanding. One thing is the space **the mind makes** — a beautiful blue vastness you paint — which is just one more content. Another is the space that **dwells in truth**: the real space that surrounds you now. The first you imagine; the second you inhabit. The sky here is a pointer, not a destination — like the finger pointing at the moon.

Thus **collectedness** is completed. You were not gathering thoughts *about* the body, the breath, the attention — you were coming into *contact* with them, one by one. Contact, not remembering. And now the same contact opens into the space that contains it all.

The Rhythm of Open Attention

The turn from the narrow to the open has a measurable imprint too. The work of Les Fehmi on Open Focus observed that, when attention spreads out and becomes peripheral, large regions of the brain can synchronize

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into a slower rhythm — the alpha band, which has been associated with relaxed alertness.

And the fastest road there is not effort, but a question without an object:

Can you feel the space between your two eyes?

Attention moved — but found nothing to grasp. Space has no edge, no weight. And with nowhere to hook onto, the grip dissolved on its own and opened. That is all: when you give attention space as its "object," it becomes awareness.

> **In the app:** many breathing exercises in the audio space are accompanied by binaural beats in the alpha band — support for this relaxed, open attention.

Short Moments, Many Times

Awareness does not need duration. You do not need to "stay" in the open field for a long time — not even for minutes. A single moment of recognition is complete, however brief; two seconds of open field are two whole seconds, not a failed version of ten minutes.

What seems to matter is not duration but repetition: many short moments, scattered through the day, build familiarity with the open more steadily than one long, effortful session. The app's microdoses and Weeks 7–8 of the program are built on this.

One condition, always: opening happens safely only on a grounded body.

Practice: Widening the Space

- **Grounding:** Sit comfortably. Close or lower your eyes. Feel the weight of the body and the rhythm of the breath.
- **Focus:** Stabilize on a point (image, sound, or sensation) for a few seconds.

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- **The question without an object:** "Can I feel the space between my eyes?" Do not search for an answer — let the question dissolve the grip.
- **Widening:** As in driving you open from the road to the surroundings and the mirrors, let attention spread in every direction. The center remains the axis of gravity.
- **Acceptance:** Listen, look, feel — without focusing, without judging. Contents come and go. You are the field.
- **Return:** If you get lost, the flash will come — "ah, I had been lost." That flash *is* awareness. Return to the open.

> **In the app:** Space microdoses.

Reflection: What changed when attention had nowhere to hook onto?

> ***If at some point you feel yourself "leaving"***
>
> *If, on opening, you feel disconnected or as though you are moving away from yourself, this is not the aim. Open your eyes, feel the soles on the ground and the weight of the body, say where you are now. You are returning to the earth. First the earth, then the sky.*

The Same Water

The first three centers were not an "antechamber" we pass through. Narrow focus and open awareness are complementary — as the zoom and the wide lens are the same camera. The tunnel was never the enemy; it is the zoom lens. You will use both all your life; freedom is not staying stuck in either.

Over time the distinction softens: the return becomes effortless, focus ceases to be a clenching, and mindfulness and awareness cease to be two things. The wave does not stop being a wave when it remembers that it is water. It simply stops fighting the sea.

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∞

Each axis has its shape: a line for the earth, a circle for the breath, a triangle for attention. The fourth has the ∞.

"Infinite" here does not mean something vast and distant. At its root, the word means *without end* — without limit. It is exactly the field we described: cosmic space, without border, without edge. The fourth step does not send you to a vast "out there"; it brings you to the infinite that was always here.

And notice where. The ∞ has neither beginning nor end, and it passes through a point at its center. That center is not up high — it is at the heart. The infinite is not a spiral upward; it is the open space centered here, grounded, at the height of the heart.

> ★ **Key Point: Attention is the point; awareness is the field within which it moves. The fourth step shifts the center from the point to the field — from the egocentric to the spatiocentric — with the body grounded and present. Short moments, many times.**

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Part 2 — Applications & Transformation

Strategies for daily life.

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Chapter 5 — The Neurodivergent Mind: Defence, Racing, the Mask

> **In this chapter**
>
> *The neurodivergent mind is not broken — it functions differently. We understand the two main states (racing/locking), the setting that sits underneath them, and the cost of the mask.*

The mind of a neurodivergent person is rarely static. It usually moves between two extreme states: it "races" or it "locks."

A MIND THAT RACES — Scattered Attention / Overload. The world becomes a chain of small hooks. Many stimuli arrive at once without a filter. *Tool: Body (Grounding) + Breath (Rhythm).*

A MIND THAT LOCKS — Stuck Attention / Hyperfocus. Like a tunnel of intense focus. It can become a trap if the object is an anxious thought or an obsession. *Tool: Body (Grounding) + Space (Release) — attention frees itself.*

> ***Strategy for Looping:*** *Use Open Awareness (Space). Remember that your thoughts happen within a wider space. You can recognize their true dimensions and gain freedom without being suffocated by them.*

Defence: The Setting Underneath

Racing and locking are not two independent weather systems. They change character according to one setting that sits beneath them: whether the system is in defence or not.

Defence is not an episode. For many of us it is the resting state — the place the system returns to when nothing is happening. There is a reason for this, and it deserves respect. Years in sensory environments you could

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not predict. Years of being corrected for reactions that felt ordinary to you. When you do not know which of your moves will be judged wrong, the system draws the only reasonable conclusion: the world requires continuous surveillance.

So defence stays open. And because it stays open, it costs continuously — even when nothing is happening.

What it looks like from inside: nothing is wrong, and yet everything is one notch too loud. A small thing lands large. A neutral face reads as a verdict. You are tired without having done anything.

And here is the crucial part. Defence does not produce your thoughts — it *selects* them. Your mind does not run toward danger because it is negative; it runs because the search has been given the parameter "find the threat." It is the same mind that plans, predicts, and creates. The setting changed, not the mind. This is why the vicious circles of Chapter 3 catch more easily on some days: you did not become weaker — the system is searching.

That changes what is worth doing. You do not win the argument with the content, because the content is not the cause — it is the result. Defence comes down through signals, not arguments: weight in the soles, one long exhale, the space around you, an environment that is not hitting you. And through time. A setting built over years does not change in one afternoon.

> ***Defence is not character.*** *You are not "too much" and you are not "too sensitive." You are a system that learned one lesson very well — and that can learn, slowly, that right now it is not needed.*

The Role of the Mechanical Mind

Locking (Hyperfocus) is often fueled by the Mechanical Mind — that part of the mind that continually analyzes the past and plans the future, without a

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stable base in the present. The Mechanical Mind is not an enemy — it is a tool that has "overheated" without the stabilizing influence of presence.

The practice does not try to stop the Mechanical Mind, but to complement it with an Open Mind — a mind that observes without analyzing, that embraces without judging, that sees beyond scenarios and perceives causes.

The Mask: The Bottle

Defence has a social form too. It is called *masking*: the daily performance of being someone else, so that the people around you feel comfortable.

It is labor, and heavy labor. Checking every word before it leaves. Calculating whether your reaction is "too much" or "not enough." Pretending the noise does not bother you. Smiling while your nervous system is screaming. Chronic masking is linked in the research to burnout, anxiety, and depression — not because you are weak, but because no function can run continuously without cost.

Zen has an image for this, 1,200 years old. An official asks the master: if you put a gosling in a glass bottle and feed it until it grows, how do you get it out without breaking the glass and without killing the goose? The master does not solve the problem. He claps his hands and calls the man's title. The man turns reflexively — and hears: "See, the goose is already out."

The bottle is form: the body, the constructed mind, the roles, the identifications. The goose is awareness — the open field of Chapter 4. And the master's answer says something very specific: you never became the bottle. **The mask was a function, never an identity.**

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> ***A clear distinction.*** *Nothing here tells you to take the mask off out there. Where and when is your decision, and it depends on your safety, your work, the people around you — things only you know. What the practice proposes is internal: to stop believing that you are the bottle, and to find the places where you can loosen it safely.*

And there is a guide for this, a bodily one. The mask is not worn on the face alone — it is worn in the jaw, the shoulders, the breath held a little high. That cost is measurable. It is the same barometer as Chapter 8: when did the jaw start to tighten, when did the breath rise. You do not have to decide anything about your identity in order to notice it.

We do not break the glass. **We loosen the bottle** — we build the conditions of safety so the system can come down out of defence. And there, with nothing added, what was always free becomes visible.

> In the Rabbit Hole: The Goose Is Out — the koan, masking, and the fourth axis.

Kindness as an Exit from Autopilot

Self-criticism is not your truth — it is an echo of words, looks, and expectations that were not met. Research suggests that intense self-criticism can activate the same threat-response circuits that react to external danger, involving the amygdala and stress hormones such as cortisol. Every time you judge yourself harshly, your brain reacts as if it were under attack.

The gentleness of this method is the stance we need to hold toward ourselves. Growth here does not mean productivity, but the flourishing of your unique potential.

Remember: your thoughts and experiences happen within a wider space of awareness. Within that open space, you can recognize their true

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dimensions. Treat yourself the way you would treat a friend who is struggling.

Reflection: My own patterns — when does my mind tend to "race"? When does it "lock"? What situations trigger it?

> ★ **Key Point: Defence does not make your thoughts — it selects them. It comes down through signals of safety and through time, not through argument. And the mask was always a function, never an identity.**

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Chapter 6 — Self-Regulation in Daily Life

> **In this chapter**
>
> *Why the daily practice is called contact, and where a mind stands when it stops standing on its constructions — along with practical tools for noisy spaces, social moments, transitions, low-energy states, and the spaces where you live.*

Where Do You Stand?

Every mind needs a point to stand on — a base from which it perceives the world and itself. And here it is worth saying plainly: in many neurodivergent minds, this base has become thought itself. The scenarios, the analyses, the inner constructions — these are not just habits. They are the ground you stand on.

There is a reason for this, and it deserves honor. When the body lives in constant alarm and the sensory world feels unreliable, the mind becomes the only room that is entirely your own — the only ground you can control. Making thought your base was not a defect. It was the best available solution — and for years, perhaps the only one.

But a base made of thought has a cost: it does not hold itself up. You have to rebuild it, moment by moment, for it to keep existing — one reason the mind never stops. If it stops, the floor is lost. The vicious circles of Chapter 3 — the "Otherwise," the "Should" — now appear from another angle: they are not merely circles. They are foundation work on ground that does not exist.

At times this base narrows into what is called a reality tunnel: a hyperfocus that has turned against you. The tunnel is not in itself the enemy — it is the very ability that lets you dive deep into what you love. But when its object is a fear, a wound, an obsession, the tunnel becomes the whole world — and the world becomes a tunnel.

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And here is the crucial part: **you cannot use attention to get out of a trap made of attention.** The function that got stuck cannot also be the rescue crew. Inside the tunnel, attention is already over-functioning — if you ask it to plan the exit too, you feed the overactivation. The exit runs through the other two centers:

- **Below — gravity.** The earth is the only base that needs neither construction nor attention to exist. It holds you whether you think of it or not. All the difference is here: thought is a base you hold up; the earth is a base that holds you.
- **Around — awareness.** The tunnel has no door at its far end — but it also has no walls all around. Space was never interrupted (Chapter 4); the tunnel exists within it. One moment without an object — the space between the eyes, the room around the sounds — and the walls reveal themselves to be clouds.

Nothing here asks you to stop thinking — that is impossible, and unnecessary. What changes is where the weight rests. Thought continues, but it stops being the floor: it becomes weather above ground that you do not have to build yourself. And the mind, relieved of the job of keeping you upright, is freed to do what it does best — to create, to predict, to play.

Contact, not Remembering

That is why the daily form of the practice is not "remembering to practice." It is **contact**: a thin, living thread toward the anchor points — the soles, the breath, the space all around — running beneath whatever you are doing. Not instead of your life; within it.

Contact is not a state you construct, nor concentration — it costs nothing (Chapter 4: awareness does not tire). It is more like the way you know, without checking, that the floor is beneath your feet.

The thread will break. That is not failure — it is designed that way. The moment you notice it — the little flash "ah, I had left" — is the bridge: you

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cross it (soles, one exhale, space) and you are in contact again. Remembering is only the moment of the bridge. Contact is the country the bridge leads to — the place from which you live.

Two seconds of true contact, many times a day — that is the whole practice of this chapter.

Self-regulation is the ability to bring your nervous system back from overactivation or underactivation to a state of balance. It begins with contact on four levels:

1. **Contact with the Body** — You feel the earth, the weight, the axis.
2. **Contact with the Breath** — You see whether the rhythm is fast, shallow, or calm.
3. **Contact with Attention** — You see where the mind has stuck (scattering or fixation).
4. **Contact with Space** — You feel whether there is openness and safety.

Practical Applications

1. In Noisy Spaces (Sensory Overload)

- Feel your feet on the ground — immediate grounding in the chaos.
- Take 3 quiet breaths with the exhale through the mouth.
- Open your peripheral vision — soften your gaze instead of focusing.
- Use headphones or a fidget toy if needed.

2. In Social Moments (Overactivation & Fatigue)

- Choose a neutral point (e.g., a plant) as a visual reference.
- Feel the feet steady — if you feel tension in the jaw, release it with an exhale.
- Use peripheral vision to stay present.

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3. With Anxiety or Tension (Immediate Regulation)

- Ground: feel the weight and the axis.
- Take 10 breaths: inhale through the nose, exhale through the mouth, slowly.
- Walk with awareness (mindful pacing) — the rhythmic movement "burns off" the anxiety.

4. When the System Shuts Down (Gentle Activation)

Up to here the tools pointed in one direction: downward, toward calm. But regulation is a dimmer, not a brake. "Shutting down" — the flat, foggy, disconnected state — is also dysregulation, and it needs the opposite move: gentle activation. When the fire has gone out, you do not blow on it hard. You add kindling:

- Sway gently (in the app: Swaying) — rhythm wakes the system without frightening it.
- Hum on the exhale — vibration is movement from within.
- Lift your gaze to the horizon or the sky — the body reads distance as an invitation.
- Walk slowly, feeling the push of each sole — and let the rhythm rise on its own.
- Warmth, light, a favorite song. Small, warm, rhythmic — that is the recipe.

The aim is not to force energy, but to let the wind rise again on its own.

Transitions: The Practice of the Threshold

For many neurodivergent people, the hardest moments of the day are not the activities — they are the seams between them: stopping one thing, starting another. The nervous system is asked to change gears without a clutch.

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Every door — literal or not — can become a threshold. Before you cross: feel the soles, one longer exhale, notice the space of the room you are entering. Three seconds. The system gets what it rarely gets — a boundary marked, not smeared. Closing the laptop, ending a call, the front door shutting behind you: all thresholds, all invitations to contact.

Building the Harbor

Self-regulation is not only what you do in the moment — it is also the conditions you set up beforehand. A vessel stays afloat more easily in a harbor than on the open sea.

Light, sound, and textures matter more than you were taught to admit — and adjusting them is regulation, not fussiness. And after every social open sea, design a harbor for decompression: half an hour, familiar, quiet, without demands. It is not avoidance, nor a luxury. It is maintenance of the vessel.

★ **Key Point:** Contact is the base. The earth holds you without your effort, the sky opens without your construction — you can stand on the real, and let thought be weather, not floor.

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Chapter 7 — The New Driver: Avoidance and Procrastination

> **In this chapter**
>
> *Between a decision and the act there is a small distance. For many neurodivergent people, and for many who carry trauma, that distance becomes an abyss. Here you see how the Fourfold Axis applies to procrastination: what the old driver is, what the mountain is, and how you move when thought and feeling won't obey.*

It isn't laziness. And it isn't bridged by thought or by feeling, but by the body: gently, without force, without hurry. This is not a way of functioning without brakes. It is a way of learning to function in small steps, as play and practice at once.

If You're Stuck Right Now

Start here; the explanation can wait. The Pocket Card in Chapter 8 is for inside the wave. This one is for when you can't begin.

GRAVITY — BREATH — SPACE — ONE STEP

> *(Weight and ground. A slow exhale. The space around you. One movement from the center.)*

1. **Gravity.** Feel your weight, the axis, the ground beneath you. Let the tension go. Stay in the now, adding nothing to it and taking nothing away — no future, no past. This is point zero.
2. **Breath.** One quiet breath, with a slow exhale.
3. **Space.** See the space you are about to move through.

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4. **One step.** The movement begins gently from the belly and the pelvis, and the limbs follow. One movement at a time, with attention shared among balance, breath and space. What you want to do stays at the edge of the mind; in front of you is only the movement you are making now.

If you feel yourself drifting away or going numb, stop and come back to your weight and the ground. That too is part of the practice, not a failure.

If you can't feel your body. With difficulty sensing the body, with disconnection, pain or fatigue, "feel your weight" may find nowhere to land. Nothing is missing in you; use another door: the fabric on your skin, the air on your hands, the farthest sound and the nearest, your gaze moving from the farthest point of the room to the nearest. One point of contact is enough. And if even that doesn't come, "I feel nothing" is itself an observation, and it is enough to stand on.

That is all of it: how to move the body, moment by moment, to do what you decided, without standing on the feeling — which may be absent, bored, or refusing. What follows is the why. Read it once you have settled.

The Old Driver

Every act needs something to manage it: to say "now," to set an order, to keep the movement going. For many of us that driver has been pressure and anxiety. If it is the only one you know, you start only when it shows up — and it usually shows up at the last minute, with the deadline over your head. Seen this way, procrastination is not laziness: it is waiting for the only driver you know.

And it doesn't bring only pressure. It brings the past: old rejections, old fears, all the pressure you received to function "normally." So you never meet the thing as it is, only as it was all the previous times. But let's be fair: the old driver worked. That is why you don't dismiss it with one decision; you replace it slowly.

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The Mountain

The act itself is rarely hard: getting up, turning on the tap, making a phone call. What makes it hard is the weight the mind adds to it: "it'll take ages," "what if it doesn't come out right." Each such thought is an attempt to control the outcome before the act, and each attempt adds weight, until the thing becomes a mountain. Facing it, you put things off, and putting off brings a moment of relief. That is why you repeat it: the mind learns that the act hurts and avoidance soothes.

So the move is not to find the strength to lift the mountain, but not to let it be built. You don't fight the refusal; you simply don't feed it, keeping your attention on what you are doing now.

Desire, Intention, and the Will of the Act

The usual advice says "find motivation." But what we call motivation is usually desire: aimed at the result — the clean body, the license in your hand. It lives in mood, and in that moment it may be absent.

Intention is something else: the direction you chose, which stands on its own without needing to be felt again at every step. It stays at the edge of the mind and orients you from there, while your attention takes the next step. When the goal comes to the front, it paralyzes; when it stays at the edge, it guides.

And there is the will of the act — not the kind that clenches. You don't manufacture it by straining: the strength belongs to the body, its vital energy, and you direct it gently with intention. Desire you feel high up, in the chest and the head; this will you feel low, in the belly, where you also feel your center of gravity. Mood and thoughts you may not control. The body, most of the time, you can move. And when even the body won't move, a point of contact remains: not always controllable, but always there.

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One kind of will is worth letting go of: the one that wants to decide how reality will be and how it will unfold. You keep the act and let go of the outcome. The outcome, not the act: the act is done whole, now, for now.

The New Driver

The new driver is mindfulness. It doesn't push you and doesn't frighten you. It is available now, whenever you call on it, and it doesn't need to burn you out to work. It lives in the card's point zero, so the act no longer carries the verdict of all the previous times: you meet it fresh.

Presence is shared among body, breath, thoughts and space, and none of them takes the wheel. That balance is also your safety: the task doesn't swell to fill you, and you don't lose the ground. When there is space around what concerns you, it takes on its real proportions.

The new driver treats you the way you would stand beside a neurodivergent child who is learning: without pressure, without blame, without hurry.

Big Goals: Information, Not Scenarios

With something big — a driving license, an application — the barrier is also the size. Here one step comes before the card: once, you write down what it involves, with information, not scenarios. What is needed, in what order, whom you ask. A scenario guesses how you will feel and breeds refusal; information simply says what is there. The unknown swells; what is written down shrinks.

Then you put the map at the edge of the mind and work only on the next step. For the license: first you go to the instructor and start working together. Not the lessons, not the exam.

Play and Practice

Avoidance feeds on the stakes: every act feels like an exam. Play removes the stakes; you aren't being tested, you are trying. Practice adds the other

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half: no attempt is a verdict. And without hurry doesn't mean slowly; it means without inner agony.

The brakes stay. Not all avoidance is an enemy: avoiding a place that floods you with sensory input, or something that wakes trauma, is protection. This chapter is about avoiding things you chose to do. And when those touch something heavy, go little by little, only as far as you can comfortably bear. Gentleness is not weakness; it is the strong choice, because it doesn't burn the ground you stand on.

When It Isn't Avoidance

For many neurodivergent people, the difficulty of starting also has a neurological basis. Avoidance and executive dysfunction look the same from outside, but they need different tools.

- **Avoidance:** you think of it and feel weight, fear, shame; the "I don't want to" has an "I'm afraid" inside it. Here, everything you have read applies.
- **Executive dysfunction:** you want it, you have decided, you feel no resistance — and you simply don't move, as if the command were missing rather than the mood. Gentleness helps, but it isn't enough; something outside you has to hold what the system cannot hold on its own.
- **Often both:** executive dysfunction brings shame, and shame builds avoidance on top. Then you work with both layers together.

External supports are not a betrayal of the method; they are the Harbor of Chapter 6, applied to starting: a five-minute timer, a list of just three steps, someone beside you doing their own work too (body doubling), a reminder on your phone, a quieter environment.

And if procrastination has become a chronic pattern that costs you work, relationships or health, or if it comes together with depression, active trauma or substance use, talk to a therapist, a psychiatrist, or someone

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who specializes in neurodivergence. It is not a failure of the practice; it is the same harbor, only larger.

Why It Changes Over Time

When every start comes with pressure and self-criticism, the act becomes linked with threat and the mind learns to avoid it. Stress research also shows that pressure impairs the prefrontal cortex, where planning and starting take place. When you do things through the body, with your attention on the moment rather than the result, the act slowly stops being linked with threat; what has been recorded changes, and the refusal loosens. And research shows that forgiving yourself for one bout of procrastination reduces the next: gentleness is not a luxury.

The śamatha tradition of calm-abiding meditation describes something similar in its nine stages: effort shrinks, not because you push harder, but because resistance lessens. It is a parallel, not a proof, and a path of years. But it begins in the same place: the body, now.

None of this changes how your brain is made. The method does not cure avoidance; it embraces and supports it. Why it works from the bottom up is explained in Chapter 11.

Reflection: Bring to mind something you are putting off. Is the act itself hard, or the mountain the mind has built around it? Is it avoidance or executive dysfunction — and how can you tell from the body? What would be the body's first small step, without waiting to want it?

> ★ **Key Point: In place of urgency and panic you put the body and its energy, the breath, and your intention. You keep the act, let go of the outcome, and move one step at a time. Avoidance you meet with gentleness; executive dysfunction you also support with tools outside yourself.**

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Chapter 8 — When the Wave Rises: Anxiety, Overload

> **In this chapter**
>
> *Two practical protocols — for intense anxiety and for overload — along with what comes before the wave, and what comes after.*

The Barometer: Before the Storm

Every wave is announced — the announcement is simply silent. A jaw that tightens. Breath rising high into the chest. Irritation at sounds you tolerated an hour ago. The same sentence read three times. These are the readings of your barometer.

The earlier you catch the wind, the less force it takes: at the first signals, one long exhale may be enough; at the peak, the whole protocol is needed. Learn your own three first signs — the reflection at the end of the chapter asks for them. Take that question as field research for the week.

Protocol 1: Immediate Response to Intense Anxiety

Intense anxiety is a "fight or flight" state that requires an immediate signal of safety to the nervous system, through body and breath.

1. **Grounding (Body)** — Feel the weight of the body, its posture, the tensions — without verbal analysis. Simply notice where you are holding the tension.
2. **Regulation (Breath)** — Close your eyes and take 3 deep breaths. Let the exhale leave slowly through the mouth, as if gently blowing on a flame.
3. **Labeling (Attention)** — If the mind sticks to a scenario, use a label ("Worry," "Scenario") and return to the breath.
4. **Opening (Space)** — Open your peripheral vision and notice the space around you. Widening reduces the sense of being trapped.

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5. **Movement & Axis** — If you can, walk a little, feeling the soles. Keep the sense of the vertical axis. Open gaze and awareness of space.

Protocol 2: Managing Overload

When everything falls on you at once, the aim is to find space to hold the stimuli without reacting. Instead of focusing on reducing anxiety, you focus on widening awareness.

1. **Grounding (Step 1)** — Feel the soles, your weight. Zero your position, as if pressing the reset button of your body.
2. **Breath (Step 2)** — Stay with its flow. The exhale through the mouth is optional, but recommended if you feel tightness.
3. **Attention (Step 3)** — Keep attention in front. Instead of being pulled by every detail, choose a stable point as your anchor.
4. **Opening (Space — Step 4)** — Soften the gaze (peripheral vision). Remember the sky: all the stimuli — sounds, lights, thoughts — are clouds passing through the open space of your awareness.

> ***Keep the distance:*** *Remember — you are not the clouds. You are the space that holds them. Simply recognizing this immediately reduces the sense of danger.*

What Not to Do

Another honest word — because inside the wave, everything below looks reasonable:

- **Do not try to think your way out.** The exit does not run through content (Chapter 6: the function that got stuck cannot also be the rescue crew).
- **Do not analyze in the middle of the wave.** "Why am I like this?" is bellows, not inquiry. Analysis can happen later — if it is still needed, which is rarer than it seems.

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- **Do not force deep inhalations.** Forceful deep breaths can heighten the alarm. The tool is the long exhale — gently.
- **Do not suppress your stims.** The rocking, the pacing, the movement of the hands — the body's own self-regulation, already at work. Let it be.
- **Do not demand calm as proof of success.** Success is the vessel staying afloat (Chapter 2).

After the Wave

No protocol says what happens afterward — and the afterward matters. When the wave passes, the mind often turns to bite: "why did I let it happen again?" Recognize it: it is the "Should" with a life jacket — the bellows re-inflating the wind that just fell.

After the wave: water, food, rest. A wave is physical exertion — treat it as such. No analysis for a few hours; let the water settle before you look at the bottom. If the wave splashed someone, a brief repair sentence later — "it was my overload talking, not you" — is worth more than a perfect apology. And kindness: you did not fail an exam. Weather passed, and you kept the vessel.

The Pocket Card

Inside the wave, no one reads paragraphs. Four words, in order:

GROUND — LONG EXHALE — LABEL — OPEN

(Soles. Through the mouth, slowly. Name the scenario. Peripheral vision.)

If you keep one thing from this chapter, keep these four words.

Reflection: What are my body's first signals when overload begins?

★ **Key Point:** Catch the wind early, keep the vessel afloat, and be kind afterward — the wave is weather, not a verdict.

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Chapter 9 — Presence Worksheet

> **In this chapter**
>
> *A one-page sheet you can fill in. It is the **short** version of the practice, for use inside the day. The full, seated version is Chapter 10; the version for inside the wave is the Pocket Card (Ch. 8).*

Aim: To return to the "now" in a few seconds. Do them in order or choose the one you need.

1. BODY / BASE

- *Observation:* I am standing / sitting. I feel my weight. I notice tensions (e.g., jaw).
- *Tool:* I imagine an axis from the head to the ground. I relax jaw and shoulders.
- *What did I feel in my body just now?*

2. BREATH / RHYTHM

- *Observation:* How is my breath? Fast, shallow, tight?
- *Tool:* Exhale through the mouth, a little slower. Feel the belly gather gently.
- *How did my breath change?*

3. ATTENTION / STABILIZATION

- *Observation:* Where is my attention? Is it racing? Is it stuck somewhere?
- *Tool:* I return to a stable point. I label the thought and return.
- *Where was my attention?*

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4. SPACE / EXPANSION

- *Observation:* Do I feel trapped? Is my attention like a tunnel?
- *Tool:* I soften my gaze. I let attention spread. Thoughts = clouds.
- *What changed when space opened?*

> ★ **Key Point: Four centers, four questions. One of them, done well, is enough.**

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Chapter 10 — The Four Stages: Step-by-Step Guide

> **In this chapter**
>
> *The **full**, sequential exercise of the Fourfold Axis, for a quiet moment. It is best done seated, but the steps can be applied at any moment. The short version for inside the day is the Presence Worksheet (Ch. 9); the version for inside the wave is the Pocket Card (Ch. 8).*

The Stance Behind the Steps

Before you begin the stages, remember: gentleness is not optional — it is the method itself. Every time you return without criticism, every time you accept distraction as part of the process — you practice kindness. Not as an idea, as an act.

Harsh self-criticism appears to engage the same threat-response circuits as external danger. The gentle return settles them. This is the road: not by fighting autopilot, but by giving it room to settle.

Treat yourself the way you would treat a friend who is struggling.

Stage 1 — Feel the Earth (Grounding)

- Sit or stand comfortably. Back upright but not tight.
- Feel the points of contact: soles, back against the seat.
- Let the weight sink into the earth.
- With each exhale, relax neck, jaw, shoulders.
- **Aim:** To feel the vertical axis — your base.

Stage 2 — Feel the Breath (Regulation)

- Close or half-close your eyes.
- Feel the path: inhale through the nose → lungs → belly, exhale in reverse.
- In tension: exhale slowly through the mouth, as if blowing out a candle.

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- **Aim:** A natural, uninterrupted rhythm — calming of the nervous system.

Stage 3 — Focus Forward (Concentration)

- Open your eyes. Choose a quiet point in front of you.
- Look at it with a soft, steady gaze.
- If thoughts come: recognize → label → return gently.
- **Aim:** Training attention to stabilize.

Stage 4 — Open into Space (Open Awareness)

- Soften the gaze. Open peripheral vision.
- See the whole visual field: right, left, up, down.
- Feel all at once: body, breath, earth, sky.
- **Aim:** An immediate sense of presence, without words or effort.

> **In the app:** the whole practice with guidance and the structured program step by step · the practice space with all the exercises.

Reflection: Which stage feels most natural to me? Where do I struggle most?

> ★ **Key Point: Four stages, in order: earth, rhythm, point, field. The order is not decoration — each one makes the next one safe.**

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Chapter 11 — The Background: Science and Wisdom

> **In this chapter**
>
> *Where the method rests: what neuroscience says about the body, the breath, attention and space; which contemplative traditions the exercises come from; and who transmitted them.*

This guide is not merely a book of exercises. For the neurodivergent mind — which is not satisfied with "do it because I say so" — it tries to show both the **how** (neuroscience), the **what** (practice), and the **why** (contemplative tradition). It does not ask for trust; it builds it through understanding.

Part A: The Scientific Foundation

The philosophy of the research. Classic mindfulness techniques can bring anxiety or "freezing" to neurodivergent people, because they often ask for immediate stillness and passive observation. This method starts from the other end: from the body upward (somatic, bottom-up) — first the nervous system is regulated, then observation comes. Research on contemplative traditions describes the same order: stable, focused attention is cultivated first, and open observation comes after. *Source: Lutz et al. (2008). Trends in Cognitive Sciences. DOI: 10.1016/j.tics.2008.01.005*

Body — Grounding & Gravity. The brain continually computes gravity and the body's relationship to the ground, with the cerebellum playing a central role in this computation. In practice, turning attention to gravity and the points of support gives the nervous system a stable, familiar reference — a sense of "here" that needs no thought. *Source: Mackrous et al. (2019). Current Biology. DOI: 10.1016/j.cub.2019.07.006*

Breath — The Vagus Nerve. The slow, prolonged exhale activates the "ventral" side of the vagus nerve, which is associated with states of calm and safety. You do not need to "convince" yourself that you are safe; in

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experience, the exhale sends the signal on its own. *Source: Porges (1995). Psychophysiology. DOI: 10.1111/j.1469-8986.1995.tb01213.x*

Attention — A Quiet DMN. The Default Mode Network (DMN) is associated with mind-wandering, rumination, and self-criticism, and is often overactive in neurodivergent brains. Farb and colleagues showed that the shift from "narrative" to direct, experiential attention (what I feel now) is associated with reduced DMN activity. Labeling and returning to sensation are exactly this shift. *Source: Farb et al. (2007). Social Cognitive and Affective Neuroscience. DOI: 10.1093/scan/nsm030*

Space — Open Awareness. In experienced meditators, increased synchronization of **gamma** brainwaves has been observed during open-awareness practice. Separately, Open Focus research links the widening of attention with a stronger **alpha** rhythm. In experience, both feel like "unsticking" from narrow hyperfocus: less exhaustion, more spaciousness. *Source: Lutz et al. (2004). PNAS. DOI: 10.1073/pnas.0407401101*

That these change with repetition rests on **neuroplasticity** — the brain's ability to reorganize itself through practice.

Further studies (title & DOI):

- Effectiveness in adult ADHD — Kim & Jung (2025). Medicine. DOI: 10.1097/md.0000000000044308
- Neurobiology & neuroplasticity of mindfulness — Calderone et al. (2024). Biomedicines. DOI: 10.3390/biomedicines12112613
- DMN connectivity & meditation — Brewer et al. (2011). PNAS. DOI: 10.1073/pnas.1112029108
- 8-week program specifically for ADHD — Zylowska et al. (2008). Journal of Attention Disorders. DOI: 10.1177/1087054707308502
- Mindfulness in autism: a systematic review, with encouraging results from studies still of low to moderate quality — Simione et al. (2024). Brain Sciences. DOI: 10.3390/brainsci14101001

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- Hyperfocus as "all or nothing" regulation — Ashinoff & Abu-Akel (2019). Psychological Research. DOI: 10.1007/s00426-019-01245-8
- Peripheral vision & soft gaze — Vater et al. (2022). Psychonomic Bulletin & Review. DOI: 10.3758/s13423-022-02117-w
- Ecological perception & the ground — Gibson (1979/2014). Psychology Press. DOI: 10.4324/9781315740218
- Brainwave entrainment (binaural) — Lane et al. (1998). Physiology & Behavior. DOI: 10.1016/S0031-9384(97)00436-8

For Chapter 7 (avoidance and procrastination):

- Procrastination as short-term mood regulation — Sirois & Pychyl (2013). Social and Personality Psychology Compass. DOI: 10.1111/spc3.12011
- Self-forgiveness for procrastinating reduces future procrastination — Wohl, Pychyl & Bennett (2010). Personality and Individual Differences. DOI: 10.1016/j.paid.2010.01.029
- Stress impairs prefrontal cortex function — Arnsten (2009). Nature Reviews Neuroscience. DOI: 10.1038/nrn2648
- New learning that changes the link between act and threat (inhibitory learning) — Craske et al. (2014). Behaviour Research and Therapy. DOI: 10.1016/j.brat.2014.04.006
- The pressure to appear "normal" (camouflaging) — Hull et al. (2017). Journal of Autism and Developmental Disorders. DOI: 10.1007/s10803-017-3166-5
- Autistic burnout — Raymaker et al. (2020). Autism in Adulthood. DOI: 10.1089/aut.2019.0079

Part B: The Spiritual Background

Mahāsatipaṭṭhāna Sutta. The Four Foundations of Mindfulness (Body, Feelings, Mind, Mental Phenomena) correspond directly to the four stages of our method.

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Dzogchen. Traditions such as Dzogchen speak of recognizing the "open space" of consciousness, in which thoughts and emotions appear and disappear without confining us.

Sufism. Sufism reminds us of the importance of grounding and of the heart as center — the connection of spirit and body.

The Transmission Lineage

The practices this method rests on were not learned from books. They were given in person, by teachers, in this order. The list contains two different things: transmissions of practice, and religious commitments (refuge). They are marked separately, because they are not the same.

- **Tai Chi / Qi Gong** *(training)* — The Great Form, from Petros Kouropoulos.
- **Sufism, Inayatiyya** *(initiation)* — Initiation and naming from Dimitris Magriotis, the tradition's appointed teacher in Greece; participation over years.
- **Dzogchen** *(transmission)* — First transmission from Chögyal Namkhai Norbu.
- **Karma Kagyu** *(refuge)* — At the Karma Kunkhyabling Centre, Athens, with a bond to the 17th Karmapa, Ogyen Trinley Dorje.
- **Nyingma / Palyul** *(refuge)* — From Khenpo Efstathios I. Liakopoulos (Kunzang Trinley Dorje Tsal, †2023), founder of the Buddhist Studies Centre "King Menander."
- **Dzogchen, continued** *(transmissions)* — From Keith Dowman; and over the last two years, two transmissions from Yeshi Namkhai, who continues his father's lineage.

None of these lineages has endorsed this book, and none bears responsibility for its form. The method is my own distillation of what was given to me.

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> ***Conclusion:*** *Science and spirituality agree — balance begins in the body, is regulated by the breath, is stabilized by attention, and expands into a sense of vastness.*

Resources & Further Reading

- Open Focus — <https://openfocus.com/home/>
- Short Moments of Open Intelligence — <https://www.holybooks.com/wp-content/uploads/Short-Moments-of-Open-Intelligence.pdf>
- LaMa Lena — Dzogchen — <https://lamalenateachings.com/>
- Merigar — International Dzogchen Community — <https://www.merigar.it/en/dzogchen-community/>
- Sufism — <https://sufi.gr/>

> ★ **Key Point: The method does not ask you to believe anything. It asks you to try, and to observe what happens in your own body.**

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7-Day Practice Journal

Note each day what you practiced, how your experience was, and what you noticed. It does not need to be perfect — it only needs to be true.

Day 1 · Monday — Date: _____

☐ Body ☐ Breath ☐ Attention ☐ Space

What I noticed today:

Day 2 · Tuesday — Date: _____

☐ Body ☐ Breath ☐ Attention ☐ Space

What I noticed today:

Day 3 · Wednesday — Date: _____

☐ Body ☐ Breath ☐ Attention ☐ Space

What I noticed today:

Day 4 · Thursday — Date: _____

☐ Body ☐ Breath ☐ Attention ☐ Space

What I noticed today:

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Day 5 · Friday — Date: _____

☐ Body ☐ Breath ☐ Attention ☐ Space

What I noticed today:

Day 6 · Saturday — Date: _____

☐ Body ☐ Breath ☐ Attention ☐ Space

What I noticed today:

Day 7 · Sunday — Date: _____

☐ Body ☐ Breath ☐ Attention ☐ Space

What I noticed today:

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Glossary

The terms of the method, one line each, with where they first appear.

Axis *(Ch. 1)* — The imagined vertical line that holds you upright without gripping. Structure without tension.

Barometer *(Ch. 8)* — The first, silent signs that precede a wave: jaw, breath, tolerance for sound.

Closed attention *(Ch. 3)* — The beam gathers to a single point. The zoom lens.

Contact *(Ch. 6)* — The everyday form of the practice: a thin thread to the soles, the breath and the space, running underneath whatever you are doing.

Defence *(Ch. 5)* — The nervous system's standing state of alert. It does not produce your thoughts; it selects them.

Drop and ocean *(Ch. 4)* — A drop is not less water than the ocean. In the same way, a brief moment of presence is whole, not smaller.

Egocentric / spatiocentric *(Ch. 4)* — Two centres of experience: everything arranged around me, or me inside something vast.

Field / point *(Ch. 4)* — Awareness is the field; attention is the point that moves within it.

Fourfold Axis *(Introduction)* — The four centres of the method: Body, Breath, Attention, Space.

Gentle return *(Ch. 3)* — Bringing attention back without self-criticism. It is not a correction of the exercise; it is the exercise.

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Golden rule *(Ch. 4)* — A few seconds of grounding before every exercise. First the earth, then the sky.

Grounding *(Ch. 1)* — Conscious contact with gravity and the ground. The first act of relaxation and the starting point of every exercise.

Gusts, systems, climate *(Ch. 2)* — The three time-scales of an emotion: minutes, days, years. Each needs different tools.

Harbour *(Ch. 6)* — The conditions you set up in advance so that regulation is easier: light, sound, textures, time to decompress.

Hyperfocus *(Ch. 5)* — The state of "locking in": very intense, narrow concentration.

Masking *(Ch. 5)* — The daily effort to appear otherwise so that those around you are comfortable. A function, never an identity.

Mechanical Mind *(Ch. 1, 5)* — The function that analyses the past and plans the future. A tool, not an enemy; dangerous only when it overheats.

Meta-awareness *(Ch. 4)* — The moment the mind notices by itself where it is: the "oh, I was gone." You do not decide it; it appears.

Microdoses *(Ch. 4)* — Very short moments of practice, many times a day. Repetition counts, not duration.

Open attention *(Ch. 3)* — The beam of attention widens and lights many things at once. The wide lens.

Open awareness *(Ch. 4)* — The open field within which experience happens. It selects nothing and holds nothing, which is why it does not tire you.

Open Mind *(Ch. 1, 5)* — The function that observes without analysing. It complements the Mechanical Mind; it does not replace it.

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Reality tunnel *(Ch. 6)* — Hyperfocus turned toward a fear or a wound, where the tunnel becomes the whole world.

Scattered attention *(Ch. 3)* — Attention jumps from stimulus to stimulus, like a monkey from branch to branch.

Short moment *(Ch. 4)* — Two to five seconds in which you leave everything exactly as it is.

Stuck attention *(Ch. 3)* — Attention sticks to one content: a thought, a worry, an obsession. Different from scattered attention, which jumps.

Thought labelling *(Ch. 3)* — You give a thought a one-word label ("Planning," "Worry") and return, instead of entering its content.

Threshold *(Ch. 6)* — The seam between two activities, turned into a three-second exercise.

Tunnel *(Ch. 4)* — Closed, intense focus. A source of strength when it is cared for, a trap when left without body and breath.

Vicious circles: "Otherwise" and "Should" *(Ch. 3)* — The two orbits in which attention gets stuck: replaying the past, and comparing with the ideal.

Wave *(Ch. 8)* — An episode of intense anxiety or overload. Weather, not a verdict.

Winds *(Ch. 2)* — Emotions, read as weather in the body and the breath, before they are translated into words.

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Appendix — The Rabbit Hole

The "Rabbit Hole" is a collection of optional, deeper texts within the app — contemplative and scientific extensions of the method, for anyone who wants to go further. They are all free. Below, organized by chapter.

Body (Ch. 1)

- **The Veils of Being** — the Matryoshka allegory: layer after layer, until the image breaks and what is inside turns out to be larger than what is outside.

Breath (Ch. 2)

- **Learning to Ride the Wind** — the breath as a wind you accompany, not control.
- **The Lute String and the Vagus Nerve** — polyvagal theory and the middle way of the nervous system (also relevant to Ch. 8).

Attention (Ch. 3)

- **The Soft Gaze: A Door That Does Not Lock** — how peripheral vision and open hearing regulate the nervous system.

Space (Ch. 4)

- **The Wave Is Not the Sea — Until It Lets Go** — the distinction between mindfulness (△) and awareness (∞).
- **You Are the Path: The Map, the Territory & the Axis** — map and territory, and the entry into the now through the axis.
- **The Seething Void** — the quantum void as an image of the open field: empty, yet full of momentary arisings.

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The Neurodivergent Mind (Ch. 5)

- **The Goose Is Out** — the koan of the goose and masking.

Stages & Tradition (Ch. 10–11)

- **Dzogchen: The Nature of Mind & The Release of Tension** — the mechanical mind and the nature of mind, tregchöd as the effortless release of tension, and where kindness comes from.
- **The Forces of the Cosmos, the Axes of the Mind** — the elements and the four axes, stated as analogy.

About the App Itself

- **What Does Sandbox Mean?** — the framing of the "safe space for practice."

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Epilogue

This road has no end. It is a way of standing within life, consciously choosing acceptance at every step.

Every moment can become a small return to gentleness and openness.

Mindfulness, in the end, is remembering that within you there already exists an open space that holds you as you are.

This space asks for nothing and rejects nothing — it simply reminds you that you are present, alive, and whole.

Keep returning. Consistency in small doses is your own greatest act of care.

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